

**Akella Raghavendra Sir**
*Founder & Chief Mentor*

[ GS PAPER II: GOVERNMENT POLICIES AND INTERVENTIONS,GS PAPER III: INFRASTRUCTURE; PORTS AND SHIPPING ]
**Publication Date: 12/09/2026**

# Sea Change: Five New Acts to Accelerate Growth in India's Maritime Sector




*India's maritime sector is undergoing a major legal transformation through five new Acts aimed at modernising shipping, ports and coastal trade. The reforms seek to enhance ease of doing business, maritime safety, trade efficiency, sustainability and India's global maritime competitiveness*

## Sea Change: Five New Acts to Accelerate Growth in India's Maritime Sector

## Syllabus Areas:

**GS Paper II:** Government policies and interventions; Centre-State relations; regulatory framework.

**GS Paper III:** Infrastructure; ports and shipping; logistics; Blue Economy; environmental sustainability; international trade.

## Why in News?

India has undertaken a major overhaul of its maritime legal framework through five new legislations — the **Merchant Shipping Act, 2025; Coastal Shipping Act, 2025; Indian Ports Act, 2025; Bills of Lading Act, 2025; and Carriage of Goods by Sea Act, 2025**.

The reforms seek to replace outdated legal provisions, simplify regulations, improve ease of doing business, strengthen maritime safety and align India's maritime sector with international standards. The Bills of Lading Act and Carriage of Goods by Sea Act came into force from **10 September 2025**.

India's maritime sector is crucial to its economy because a substantial share of the country's external trade by volume moves through the sea. Ports and shipping are therefore closely linked with **trade, logistics, industrial development, energy security and employment**.

The new laws seek to create a **modern, integrated and globally aligned maritime governance framework**, supporting India's broader objectives under **Maritime Vision 2047**.

## What Are the Five New Acts?

## 1. Merchant Shipping Act, 2025

The Act modernises India's legal framework for merchant shipping and seeks to improve **ease of doing business** and regulatory clarity.

Key areas include:

- Welfare and skill development of seafarers
- Maritime safety and navigation
- Protection of the marine environment
- Alignment with International Maritime Organization (IMO) standards
- Strengthening India's shipping capabilities

The reform is important for developing a competitive Indian merchant fleet and improving India's position in global maritime trade.

## 2. Coastal Shipping Act, 2025

The Act provides a dedicated framework for regulating and promoting coastal shipping.

Coastal shipping can provide a **cost-effective and relatively greener alternative** to road-based freight transportation. The Act also seeks greater integration between **coastal shipping and inland waterways**.

It simplifies the regulatory framework for Indian vessels engaged in coastal trade and provides for greater transparency through a public database.

The larger objective is to increase the use of India's coastline for domestic freight movement while reducing logistics costs and congestion on land-based transport networks.

## 3. Indian Ports Act, 2025

The Act replaces the century-old **Indian Ports Act, 1908** with a modern framework for port governance.

It focuses on:

- Integrated and evidence-based port development
- Centre-State coordination
- Strengthening State Maritime Boards
- Dispute resolution
- Safety and security
- Pollution prevention
- Digitalisation and ease of doing business

The Act also establishes the **Maritime State Development Council** as a statutory consultative mechanism between the Centre and coastal States.

## 4. Bills of Lading Act, 2025

A **bill of lading** is an important document in maritime trade that records the receipt and carriage of goods and establishes certain rights and obligations of the parties involved.

The new Act modernises the legal framework governing bills of lading and seeks greater clarity regarding **rights, liabilities and transfer of ownership**.

By reducing ambiguity and potential litigation, it aims to facilitate smoother and more efficient maritime commerce.

## 5. Carriage of Goods by Sea Act, 2025

The Act replaces the earlier colonial-era framework governing the carriage of goods by sea.

It retains the **Hague-Visby Rules**, helping maintain India's alignment with internationally recognised maritime practices.

The legislation seeks to improve **transparency, legal certainty and commercial efficiency** in the transportation of goods by sea.

## Why Are These Reforms Significant?

The five Acts represent more than a change in maritime legislation. They indicate a broader shift towards developing India as a **competitive maritime and logistics hub**.

Their potential significance includes:

- **Lower logistics costs:** Greater use of coastal shipping and efficient ports can improve freight movement.
- **Trade competitiveness:** Modern maritime laws can facilitate smoother international trade.
- **Blue Economy:** Better utilisation of maritime resources can support sustainable economic growth.
- **Ease of doing business:** Simplified regulations can encourage private investment.
- **Employment:** Expansion of shipping, ports, shipbuilding and maritime services can generate jobs.
- **Environmental sustainability:** Greater emphasis on pollution prevention and greener transport can support sustainable development.
- **Strategic importance:** A stronger domestic maritime ecosystem can enhance India's economic and strategic presence in the Indian Ocean Region.

## Challenges

The effectiveness of these reforms will depend on implementation. India needs continued investment in **port infrastructure, multimodal connectivity, shipbuilding, maritime technology and skilled manpower**.

Coordination between the Centre, States, port authorities and private stakeholders will also be essential. At the same time, maritime expansion must balance economic objectives with **marine environmental protection and pollution control**.

## Way Forward

India's maritime strategy needs to move beyond ports alone towards an integrated ecosystem covering **shipping, coastal transport, inland waterways, logistics, shipbuilding, maritime services and environmental sustainability**.

Effective implementation of the new laws, combined with infrastructure development and technological modernisation, can help India strengthen its maritime capabilities and realise the objectives of **Maritime Vision 2047 and Viksit Bharat 2047**.

